

Austrian Nonprofit Sector Research

1. Introduction

Research on Austria's charitable, third, and nonprofit sector shows a **large, historically rooted, state-entangled civil society system** whose economic center of gravity lies in social and health services. Austria is repeatedly characterized as corporatist or neo-corporatist, meaning nonprofits deliver major public-welfare functions while relying heavily on government finance and contractual ties (Meyer et al., 2021; Heitzmann & Simsa, 2004; Pennerstorfer et al., 2020). The sector is also economically substantial: more than 122,000 CSOs are reported nationally, roughly 5% of the paid workforce works in the sector, and volunteering remains widespread (Bauer & Greiling, 2023; Heitzmann & Simsa, 2004).

The core literature converges on a few anchor points. First, Austrian nonprofits have deep legal and historical roots, with many active organizations dating to the nineteenth century and the 1867 associations law serving as a key institutional foundation (Neumayr, 2015). Second, service-providing nonprofits dominate important welfare fields: nonprofits account for 89% of value added in social work without accommodation and almost 45% in residential care, and in several human-service subfields they employ most of the workforce (Pennerstorfer et al., 2020; Reitzinger & Pennerstorfer, 2021; Meyer et al., 2023). Third, this model creates both resilience and vulnerability: Austria's nonprofit social-services sector weathered the 2008 crisis better than many peers, but experienced persistently slower growth afterward and rising concentration (Pennerstorfer et al., 2020). Fourth, recent research emphasizes crisis governance, migration support, accountability pressures, and emerging environmental and digital adaptation challenges (Meyer et al., 2021; Simsa, 2017; Greiling & Stötzer, 2015; Bauer & Greiling, 2023).

Is Austria's nonprofit sector strongly shaped by state partnership and public funding?

Requires at least 5 papers that directly answer your question. Try adjusting your query to find more papers.

FIGURE 1 Consensus on Austrian state-nonprofit partnership model

The meter points strongly toward yes. Across historical, policy, and sectoral studies, Austrian nonprofits are consistently described as deeply tied to government, especially in social services where public funding often exceeds half of sector revenue and approaches 80% in some segments (Pape et al., 2019; Pennerstorfer et al., 2020; Meyer et al., 2023).

2. Methods

This deep search synthesized research from Consensus, which searches more than 170 million papers across Semantic Scholar, PubMed, and other sources. The workflow identified 244,769 initial search hits, screened 235 papers after retrieval expansion and relevance filtering, judged 135 as eligible, and included the top 50 most relevant papers for synthesis.

Search Strategy

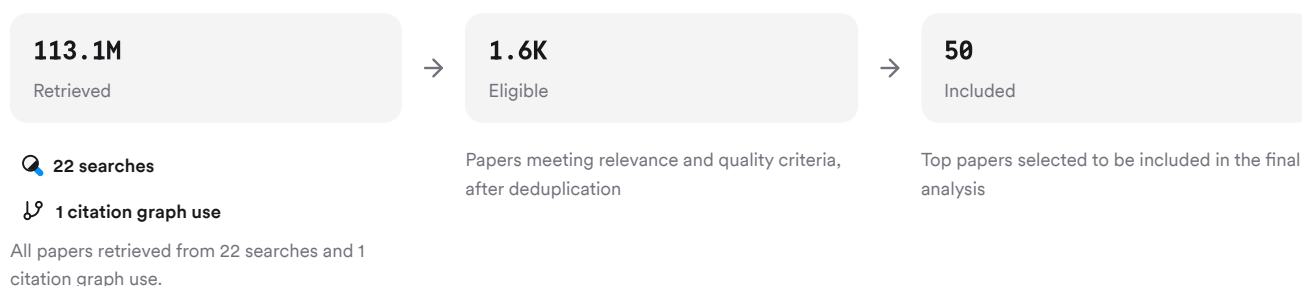


FIGURE 2 Paper identification, screening, and inclusion flow

Searches combined Austrian nonprofit, charitable, third-sector, NGO, governance, funding, crisis, reform, and comparative civil-society terms.

3. Results

3.1 Key Papers

A small set of papers anchors the field by defining Austria's nonprofit regime, quantifying its welfare role, and tracing how crisis and policy change reshape state–sector relations (Meyer et al., 2021; Pennerstorfer et al., 2020; Meyer et al., 2023). These studies are foundational because they link historical corporatism to current service delivery, finance, and governance outcomes (Heitzmann & Simsa, 2004; Neumayr, 2015).

Paper	Summary
(Meyer et al., 2021)	Long-run crisis scarring in social services (Pennerstorfer et al., 2020)
(Maier et al., 2022)	Defines corporatist COVID-era partnership model (Meyer et al., 2021)
(Stötzer et al., 2022)	Welfare partnership passed stress test unevenly (Meyer et al., 2023)

FIGURE 3 Foundational papers in Austrian nonprofit research

3.2 Sector Structure

Austria's nonprofit sector is historically broad but structurally concentrated in a few major welfare domains. Social services are largely provided by nonprofits and mainly financed by government (Reitzinger & Pennerstorfer, 2021; Pennerstorfer et al., 2020). More than 3,000 CSOs work in health, residential care, and social work, employing almost 150,000 people and generating about 65% of the sector's total GDP contribution (Meyer et al., 2021).

Dimension	Austrian Evidence	Citations
Historical roots	Many active organizations date to 19th century	(Neumayr, 2015)
Legal base	1867 associations law foundational	(Neumayr, 2015)
Social-service dominance	89% of social-work value added	(Pennerstorfer et al., 2020)
Public dependence	Government income near 80%	(Pennerstorfer et al., 2020)
Vienna density	About one CSO per 116 inhabitants	(Maier et al., 2022)

FIGURE 4 Structural features of Austrian nonprofit sector

The same corporatist pattern appears in Vienna's organizational ecology, where government funding is especially prominent in health, social services, education, and research, while liberal philanthropy remains comparatively limited (Maier et al., 2022).

3.3 Crises and Adaptation

The strongest applied literature examines how Austrian nonprofits respond to systemic shocks. After 2008, the nonprofit social-services sector remained resilient in comparative terms, but its growth rate slowed persistently and market concentration increased (Pennerstorfer et al., 2020). By the mid-2010s, job growth had roughly halved relative to the pre-crisis period, and firm entry weakened after 2013 (Reitzinger & Pennerstorfer, 2021).

During COVID-19, Austrian nonprofits in social and health care both faced severe operational strain and performed crucial public functions (Stötzer et al., 2022; Kaltenbrunner et al., 2022). Reported pressures included higher demand, rising costs, income losses, reorganization of work, psychological stress, and uncertainty about cost coverage (Stötzer et al., 2022; Meyer et al., 2021). Coping mechanisms centered on digitalization, task forces, leadership, teamwork, communication, and resilient interpersonal dynamics such as trust and shared crisis understanding (Grüb-Martin et al., 2026; Kaltenbrunner et al., 2022).

The 2015 refugee crisis revealed another side of Austrian civil society. Civil society actors were crucial for maintaining humanitarian standards and effective crisis management, but did so under substantial strain (Simsa, 2017). Refugee-support organizations ranged from dominant church-related welfare bodies to smaller autonomous groups combining service delivery with radical critique and inclusive governance (Jong & Ataç, 2017).

3.4 Governance and Emerging Research

Governance research emphasizes accountability, regulation, and uneven inclusion. In Austrian social services, nonprofit–government relationships are increasingly regulated through performance-based contracts that expand external accountability duties and shift power toward funders (Greiling & Stötzer, 2015). Austria also lacks a single legal definition or dedicated legal form for CSOs, which complicates regulation and crisis targeting (Meyer et al., 2021).

Several newer lines of work widen the agenda. Environmental integration in large Austrian social-service and healthcare nonprofits remains early-stage, with many aiming only for minimal compliance with upcoming EU reporting rules (Bauer & Greiling, 2023). Research infrastructure is improving through a new Vienna CSO dataset covering 358 representative and 235 large organizations with detailed data on goals, staffing, finances, and collaboration (Terzieva et al., 2024). Meanwhile, lower-ranked but important studies show the sector’s reach into hospitals, housing, foundations, fundraising labels, and service innovation, including evidence that private nonprofit hospitals in Austria outperform public hospitals on technical efficiency and that Austrian charity-label effects are real but modest and strongest for lesser-known organizations (Czypionka et al., 2014; Stötzer et al., 2021).

Results Timeline

Austria’s nonprofit research moves from historical foundations to crisis governance and new compliance pressures.

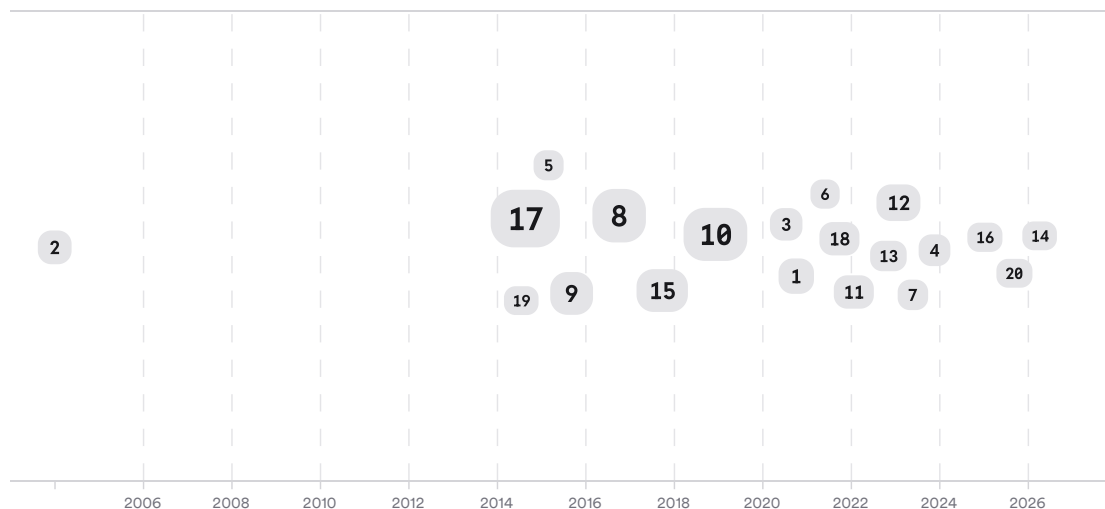


FIGURE 5 Timeline of Austrian nonprofit research; larger markers indicate more citations

The timeline shows a clear arc: early work established historical and regime-based interpretations, mid-period work examined accountability, migration, and social enterprise, and recent work focuses on COVID resilience, sector concentration, sustainability reporting, and new data infrastructure (Neumayr, 2015; Greiling & Stötzer, 2015; Simsa, 2017; Bauer & Greiling, 2023).

Top Contributors

Type	Name	Papers
Author	Michael Meyer	[1905c27666285fe696fd864b90ec37cc][7d92bb4cb218573e979677f97895e352] [dbc22d297bbb5d5cb29e7b0548c0b25d][844ef3e39f5c5925bb45d4c1b75093c7] [a0cac5595c695b1e87f5986169d51947][fc70532819395086bf889666b8ee820d] [a9c4f9f59a4d5d2fbc4f64d9ad6ac891][b7444cc41748574886b85f99bb60369c]
Author	Ulrike Schneider	[74b85a28306a57c2ac6244fb37d9a44a][1905c27666285fe696fd864b90ec37cc] [fc70532819395086bf889666b8ee820d][a9c4f9f59a4d5d2fbc4f64d9ad6ac891] [cb9bf1390d41534db1e8b6279bd106d9]
Author	Astrid Pennerstorfer	[74b85a28306a57c2ac6244fb37d9a44a][7d92bb4cb218573e979677f97895e352] [33afc3a2e248537281f289f56d273826]
Journal	<i>VOLUNTAS: International Journal of Voluntary and Nonprofit Organizations</i>	[74b85a28306a57c2ac6244fb37d9a44a][ac6ec44ca330542db7eb8892c5b7d00a] [32645229aa9f5805b4dd1723f854d5fe][3c0e056e23595d4f832a0c896e7be348] [b7444cc41748574886b85f99bb60369c][92a3c23d0d925b98ac9132bb7c40baec]
Journal	<i>Nonprofit Policy Forum</i>	[7d92bb4cb218573e979677f97895e352][883839cc24ce518bacc8da96142e308a]
Journal	<i>Social Inclusion</i>	[a8c9886e502d5cd4894d9b9d9dc2b3a3]

FIGURE 6 Authors and journals most frequent in included papers

4. Discussion

The literature is strongest on Austria's welfare-service core. Multiple studies using administrative data, surveys, and qualitative interviews converge on the same structural claim: Austrian nonprofits are central service providers in a corporatist welfare system and depend heavily on public finance (Pennerstorfer et al., 2020; Meyer et al., 2021; Meyer et al., 2023). That convergence across methods makes the basic regime diagnosis robust.

The evidence is weaker when claims move beyond structure into performance or sector-wide causality. For example, concentration after the 2008 crisis is supported in social services, but mainly within that subsector rather than the whole nonprofit field (Pennerstorfer et al., 2020; Reitzinger & Pennerstorfer, 2021). COVID studies are rich and timely, but they focus mainly on large social and healthcare NPOs, limiting generalization to advocacy, arts, and volunteer-led groups (Stötzer et al., 2022; Bauer & Greiling, 2023).

Important blind spots remain. Austria still lacks clean official sector boundaries, and several studies note the difficulty of building representative datasets because nonprofits are not registered as such in a single legal-statistical system (Meyer et al., 2021; Svidroňová & Vaceková, 2014). Emerging issues such as environmental reporting, digital fundraising, migrant inclusion, and nonprofit exclusion from migration governance are visible in the corpus, but each is supported by a relatively small number of studies (Bauer & Greiling, 2023; Harken et al., 2025; Long et al., 2025; Schweitzer, 2022).

Claim	Evidence Strength	Reasoning	Papers
Austrian nonprofits are structurally intertwined with the	 Strong	Repeated across historical, comparative, and sector studies	(Meyer et al., 2021; Heitzmann & Simsa, 2004; Meyer et al., 2023)

Claim	Evidence Strength	Reasoning	Papers
state, especially in welfare services		with direct funding and employment evidence	
Social services are the economic core of Austria's nonprofit sector	 Strong	Administrative and sector studies consistently show dominant value added, employment, and service shares	(Pennerstorfer et al., 2020; Reitzinger & Pennerstorfer, 2021; Meyer et al., 2021)
Major crises increased pressure and concentration but did not break the welfare partnership	 Moderate	Strong evidence in social services and COVID-era human services, but not all subsectors are equally covered	(Pennerstorfer et al., 2020; Meyer et al., 2023; Benevolenski et al., 2022)
Accountability and performance-contracting have shifted nonprofit-government power relations	 Moderate	Good governance evidence, but concentrated in social-service contracting rather than the whole sector	(Greiling & Stötzer, 2015)
Austrian nonprofits are broadly prepared for environmental and digital transformation	 Weak	Available studies instead suggest early-stage adaptation and fragmented evidence	(Bauer & Greiling, 2023; Harken et al., 2025)

FIGURE 7 Key claims and supporting evidence in corpus

5. Conclusion

The literature portrays Austria's charitable and third sector as a historically entrenched, welfare-centered nonprofit system whose defining feature is partnership with the state. That partnership gives the sector scale and policy relevance, but also exposes it to funding dependence, accountability expansion, and uneven crisis effects (Pennerstorfer et al., 2020; Meyer et al., 2021).

Research Gaps

The biggest gap is breadth beyond the social-service core. Research is dense on welfare nonprofits, COVID response, and state contracting, but thinner on advocacy groups, philanthropic foundations, environmental transition, and digital fundraising.

Topic/Outcome	Funding structure	Long-term outcomes	Representative datasets	Comparative evidence
Social services	10	8	7	5
Volunteering	4	3	4	3
Refugee and migrant support	4	2	2	3
Foundations and philanthropy	2	1	1	2

Topic/Outcome	Funding structure	Long-term outcomes	Representative datasets	Comparative evidence
Sustainability and digitalization	2	1	1	2

Open Research Questions

Future work should move from describing the Austrian model to testing how it changes under fiscal, ecological, and political stress.

Question	Why
How does heavy public-funding dependence affect innovation and advocacy capacity across different Austrian nonprofit fields?	Austria's corporatist model is well described, but cross-field consequences for autonomy and mission drift remain undermeasured.
Do smaller volunteer-led Austrian nonprofits adapt to crises differently than large welfare organizations?	COVID research centers on large service providers, leaving the broader organizational ecology poorly understood.
Will environmental and digital compliance pressures accelerate concentration in Austrian nonprofits?	Early evidence suggests low preparedness, which could disproportionately burden smaller organizations and reshape sector structure.

Austrian nonprofit research therefore supports a clear conclusion: the sector is large, welfare-critical, and durable, but its future will depend on how this state-centered model handles concentration, compliance, and diversification.

These search results were found and analyzed using Consensus, an AI-powered search engine for research. Try it at <https://consensus.app>. © 2026 Consensus NLP, Inc. Personal, non-commercial use only; redistribution requires copyright holders' consent.

References

- Bauer, P., & Greiling, D. (2023). Greening Austrian social service and healthcare non-profits. *Heliyon*, 10. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.heliyon.2023.e23767>
- Benevolenski, V. B., Ivanova, N., & Jakobson, L. (2022). Social Origins Theory: Untapped Potential and the Test by the Pandemic Crisis. *Nonprofit Policy Forum*, 0. <https://doi.org/10.1515/npf-2022-0029>
- Czypionka, T., Kraus, M., Mayer, S., & Röhring, G. (2014). Efficiency, ownership, and financing of hospitals: The case of Austria. *Health Care Management Science*, 17, 331-347. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10729-013-9256-9>
- Greiling, D., & Stötzer, S. (2015). Performance Accountability as a Driver for Changes in Nonprofit–Government Relationships: An Empirical Insight from Austria. *VOLUNTAS: International Journal of Voluntary and Nonprofit Organizations*, 26, 1690 - 1717. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11266-015-9609-8>
- Grüb-Martin, B., Martin, S., & Kaltenbrunner, K. (2026). Crisis, adaptation and recovery: A phase-based exploration of Austrian non-profit organizations during COVID-19. *Annals of Public and Cooperative Economics*. <https://doi.org/10.1111/apce.70043>
- Harken, S., Mertins, V., & Urselmann, M. (2025). Online Fundraising for Nonprofit Organizations via Social Media Marketing: A Critical Success Factors Analysis in Germany, Austria, and Switzerland. *Journal of Philanthropy*. <https://doi.org/10.1002/nvsm.70028>
- Heitzmann, K., & Simsa, R. (2004). From Corporatist Security to Civil Society Creativity: The Nonprofit Sector in Austria. 713-731. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-322-80980-3_34

- Jong, S. D., & Ataç, I. (2017). Demand and Deliver: Refugee Support Organisations in Austria. *Social Inclusion*, 5, 28-37. <https://doi.org/10.17645/si.v5i3.1003>
- Kaltenbrunner, K., Stötzer, S., Grüb, B., & Martin, S. F. (2022). Individual-based and interactional resilience mechanisms in social and healthcare service NPOs during the COVID-19 pandemic: Handling a disruptive extreme context in Austria. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 13. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2022.897790>
- Long, Y., Luo, W., & Terzieva, B. (2025). Bridging Divides or Widening Gaps? Nonprofit Organizations' Efforts for Migrant Inclusion in Two Global Cities. *Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Quarterly*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/08997640251387954>
- Maier, F., Meyer, M., & Terzieva, B. (2022). Toward a Better Understanding of Social Origins Theory: A Historical Narrative of Vienna's Civil Society Organizations. *Global Perspectives*. <https://doi.org/10.1525/gp.2022.36570>
- Meyer, M., Millner, R., Pennerstorfer, A., & Vandro, P. (2021). Partnership in Times of COVID-19: Government and Civil Society in Austria. *Nonprofit Policy Forum*, 12, 65 - 92. <https://doi.org/10.1515/npf-2020-0052>
- Meyer, M., Millner, R., Mehrwald, M., & Rameder, P. (2023). A Test for the Welfare-Partnership: Austria's Nonprofit Human Service Organizations in Times of Covid-19. *Human Service Organizations: Management, Leadership & Governance*, 48, 223 - 236. <https://doi.org/10.1080/23303131.2023.2186556>
- Neumayr, M. (2015). Giving in Austria: A Corporatist Relationship between the Nonprofit Sector and the State. 100-117. https://doi.org/10.1057/9781137341532_7
- Pape, U., Brandsen, T., Pahl, J. B., Pielniński, B., Baturina, D., Brookes, N., Chaves-Ávila, R., Kendall, J., Matančević, J., Petrella, F., Rentzsch, C., Richez-Battesti, N., Savall-Morera, T., Simsa, R., & Zimmer, A. (2019). Changing Policy Environments in Europe and the Resilience of the Third Sector. *VOLUNTAS: International Journal of Voluntary and Nonprofit Organizations*, 31, 238 - 249. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11266-018-00087-z>
- Pennerstorfer, A., Reitzinger, S., & Schneider, U. (2020). The Scarring Effect of the 2008 Economic Crisis: Growth and Growth Decline in Austria's Nonprofit Social Services Sector. *VOLUNTAS: International Journal of Voluntary and Nonprofit Organizations*, 1-15. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11266-020-00234-5>
- Reitzinger, S., & Pennerstorfer, A. (2021). The size–growth relationship in the social services sector in Austria. *Service Business*, 15, 445 - 466. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11628-021-00447-8>
- Schweitzer, R. (2022). “Voluntary Return” without Civil Society?. *Migration and Society*. <https://doi.org/10.3167/arms.2022.050104>
- Simsa, R. (2017). Leaving Emergency Management in the Refugee Crisis to Civil Society? The Case of Austria. *Journal of Applied Security Research*, 12, 78 - 95. <https://doi.org/10.1080/19361610.2017.1228026>
- Stötzer, S., Kaltenbrunner, K., Grüb, B., & Martin, S. F. (2022). Coping with COVID-19 – Which Resilience Mechanisms Enabled Austrian Nonprofit Organizations to Weather the Pandemic Storm?. *Schmalenbachs Zeitschrift Fur Betriebswirtschaftliche Forschung*, 74, 497 - 535. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s41471-022-00146-8>
- Stötzer, S., Martin, S. F., & Broidl, C. (2021). Using Certifications to Signal Trustworthiness and Reduce the Perceived Risk of Donors – An Exploratory Investigation into the Impact of Charity Labels. *Journal of Nonprofit & Public Sector Marketing*, 35, 265 - 289. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10495142.2021.1954131>
- Svidroňová, M., & Vaceková, G. (2014). Comparison of Development of Non-governmental Organizations and the Current State of Their Funding in Slovakia and Austria. *Review of Economic Perspectives*, 14, 267 - 286. <https://doi.org/10.2478/revecp-2014-0014>
- Terzieva, B., Maier, F., Meyer, M., & Burkart, C. (2024). Cross-Sectional Organizational-Level Survey Data on Civil Society Organizations in the Metropolitan Region of Vienna, Austria. *Research Data Journal for the Humanities and Social Sciences*. <https://doi.org/10.1163/24523666-bja10052>